

JUST CLICK AND CALL

It's good news for Indian telecom users. With two of the largest service providers set to join the Internet telephony bandwagon, international long distance calls could get cheaper.

■ By Nandini Valsh

At 10 p.m. sharp, Rati Kapoor, a 52-year-old homemaker from Kanpur, logs on to her computer to speak to her daughter Shruti, some 10,000 miles away in Riverside, California, who too stays online same time. It is a daily ritual for both, unless, of course, unavoidable.

"I wish I could do this from the regular landline," says Kapoor, who uses Skype's Voice-over Internet Protocol

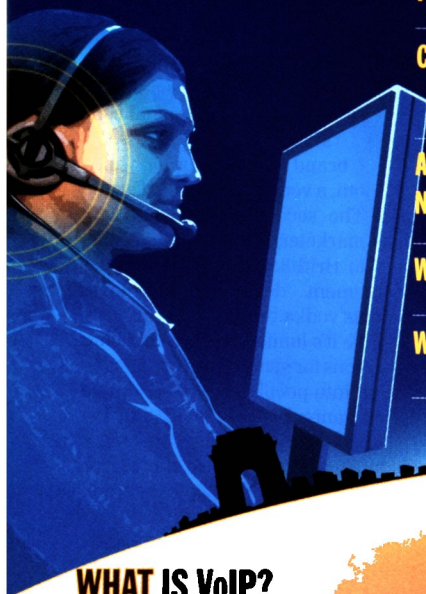
(VOIP) service to make her call. While it is extremely popular because of its low cost—a PC-to-PC call anywhere is free while a PC-to-phone call to the US is charged at \$0.024 or Re 0.95 per minute—the general complaint is that the voice breaks and the connection gets severed very often.

The good news, however, is that Kapoor's wish is now coming true with the Bharat Sanchar Nigam (BSNL) planning to start its VOIP service in December. Its sibling Mahanagar

Telephone Nigam (MTNL) has already introduced the service. Not only will the calls be cheaper at Re 1 per minute to the US, the UK, Canada and other countries, but making a call will also not require a PC. Instead, an analog telephone adaptor system will be employed, which will allow a standard telephone to be plugged into a broadband connection. The quality, assures MTNL Chairman and Managing Director R.S.P. Sinha, will be "of landline grade". So far, 500 applications for connection

THE LONG & SHORT OF IT

The different legs of Internet telephony and how they pair up against each other



	PC TO PC	PC TO PHONE
HOW IT WORKS	Download free software like Skype on your PC to chat abroad by connecting a microphone to the computer	Call a mobile or landline abroad through your PC or receive calls on your PC from a mobile/landline
DOMESTIC CALLS	Allowed	Not Allowed
ISD CALLS	Allowed	Allowed
PLAYERS	Skype, Yahoo, Google, AOL, MSN	Skype, Yahoo, Google, AOL, MSN
CALL CHARGES	Free	Calls to London at Re 0.67 per minute on Yahoo while calling the US on Skype costs Re 0.95 per minute
ACCESSORIES NEEDED	PC microphone/headset, broadband connection	PC microphone/headset, broadband connection
WHERE IT SCORES	Calls are free	Users are not bound to their PC
WHERE IT DOESN'T	Poor voice quality, disconnections	Poor voice quality

WHAT IS VoIP?

VoIP or Internet telephony involves routing of voice conversations over the Internet or any Internet protocol-based network enabling cheaper calls

